

Explaining Democracy's Origins

Lessons from South Asia

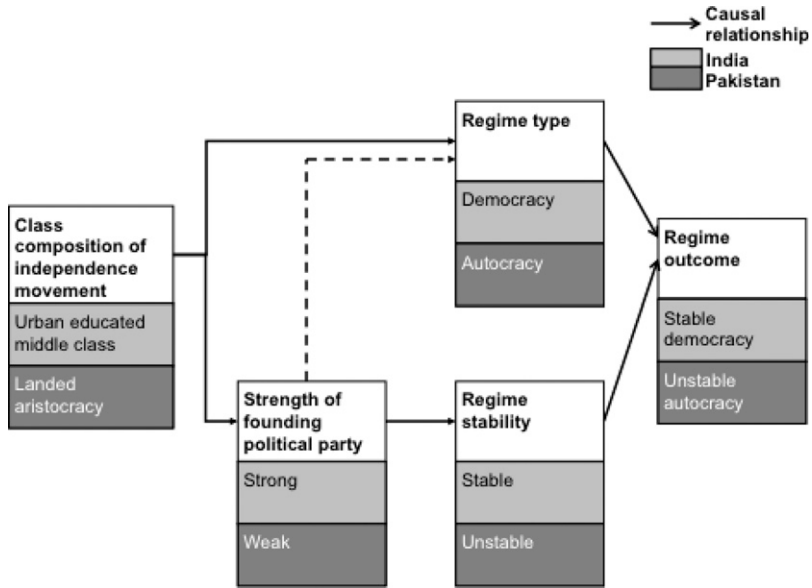
Maya Tudor

Why have some postcolonial states been able to establish durable democracies whereas others frequently oscillate between fragile democracies and unstable autocracies? What role do political parties play in brokering stability and promoting democracy during the crucial regime-building window of national independence? Under what conditions do democracy-enhancing political parties initially come into being? To shed new light upon these fundamental questions of comparative democratization, I analyze why India and Pakistan emerged from shared colonial rule and immediately embarked upon markedly different democratic trajectories in the decade after independence. During that decade, Pakistan's constitution-making remained stalemated, national elections were forestalled, and eight national administrations cycled through power with increasing rapidity. Two extralegal dismissals of Pakistan's Constituent Assembly were followed by a military coup that ushered in over a decade of military rule. In contrast, India ratified its constitution in 1950, installed an elected chief executive who effectively subordinated the military and civilian bureaucracy, and held free and fair national elections on the basis of universal adult suffrage in 1952. What explains the puzzling democratic divergence depicted in Figure 1?

Employing original archival work, interviewing, and secondary sources to examine broader patterns of political conflict and institution building in the three decades before and one decade after India and Pakistan's twin independences, I argue that these divergent democratization trajectories are best explained by the interests of the dominant social classes in each country's independence movement and the strength of the dominant political party built to pursue such interests. This argument offers several theoretical insights that advance the current state of democratization literature.

Foremost, this article sounds a cautious note on the new structural theories explaining democratization. Neomodernization approaches to democratization, best exemplified by Carles Boix and Daron Acemoglu and James Robinson, acknowledge that struggles between conflicting social groups, often classes, are central to democratization

Figure 1 The Argument



prospects, but propose that a primary, if not the primary, analytic engine of democratization is an ahistorical economic inequality.¹ These works posit that middling levels of inequality, across all historical periods and political contexts, promote democratization because of how inequality affects democratization's costs and benefits for elites and masses. But the argument developed here shows how these divergent democratization trajectories could not have been read off of levels of group inequality or income quintiles. Rather, the ways in which the power of certain social groups was entrenched and resisted by the colonial regime critically influenced who (urban, educated Hindus versus landed Muslims), when (early versus late), and how (reliance on colonial measures to protect power versus building a coherent, programmatic, and well-organized political party to access power) class groups mobilized in the lead up to the critical regime-building window after independence. Once taken, such decisions powerfully affected each country's subsequent democratization trajectory on their own terms. The explanation developed herein thus underscores that while distributive concerns are pivotal to the democratization decisions of powerful social groups, perceptions of class interests are critically shaped by strategic but historically specific political interactions.

Moreover, this article highlights the mutually conditioning roles of class cleavages and political parties in driving democratization. Whereas classical modernization theorists posited that democratization would simply accompany economic development, generations of scholars have since stressed the pivotal role of contingent class cleavages and elite divides in explaining democratization.² This literature neglected to ascribe

any substantive role in democratization to political parties however. At the same time, newer scholarship stresses the role of strong parties in creating stable regimes, but has generally remained silent on when and why strong parties emerge.³ This study highlights the intimate connections between the two by showing how the political party brokering democratic stability in India was built in the historically specific pursuit of class interests but subsequently assumed its own causal relevance to democratization. In Pakistan it was precisely because a strong political party did not emerge that regular reversions to autocracy, the defining characteristic of regime instability, followed.

Finally, this study brings the democratization experiences of South Asia to bear on debates that have been largely informed by studies of Europe and Latin America. Standard case selection methodology suggests choosing theoretically deviant cases to help improve existing theories. Dismissing the Indian case of democratization as a single empirical anomaly is simply inadequate when that case constitutes over one-sixth of the world's population. Moreover, the manifold structural similarities between India and Pakistan means that the comparison forms a rare social science approximation of a natural experiment in which many alternative explanations can be readily eliminated, thereby facilitating the task of drawing compelling causal inferences. As Table 1 indicates, these large, poor, postcolonial, and ethnically diverse countries gained independence at the same moment in history with broadly similar colonial institutions, were governed as democracies as their sovereign constituent assemblies debated constitutions, were immediately destabilized by challenges to their territorial integrities, and upon independence were governed by dominant parties created well before independence. Despite this, India's stable democracy and Pakistan's unstable autocracy emerged immediately after independence.

Historical Class Cleavages Propel Political Organization

During the close of the nineteenth century in colonial India, the strategic pursuit of historically understood class interests spurred on the creation of political movements that alternatively promoted and resisted democratic reform. **The Indian independence movement was founded by an educated, urban, and tiny middle class that viewed employment in the British Indian colonial state as its best means of achieving upward mobility.** As a direct consequence of the state's educational policy, a new group of indigenous, educated, and urban elite was emerging. As the numbers of this new elite exceeded available employment opportunities, they lobbied the colonial government through regional associations to expand indigenous employment.

The colonial government, whose local authority buttressed and was buttressed by the authority of the large, titled landlords it nominated to its legislative councils, resisted all reform efforts by labeling these high-caste individuals unrepresentative of India's manifold political interests. Conceding even partial representation, colonial government officials wrote, would place hundreds of different interests "under the domination of a microscopic minority."⁴ As almost two-thirds of congressmen were

Table 1 Alternative Democratization Explanations

Alternative Explanation	Direction of Effect	India	Pakistan
Economic Development <i>Lipset (1959), Przeworski et al. (2000)</i>	Positive	*1950 Per Capita GDP: \$619	*1950 Per Capita GDP: \$643
British Colonial Rule <i>Huber, Rueschemeyer and Stephens (1993)</i>	Positive	√	√
Inequality <i>Boix (2003), Acemoglu and Robinson (2006)</i>	Inverted U-Shape	**Gini Index: 31.9 (1988)	**Gini Index: 33.4 (1987)
Ethno-Linguistic Fractionalization <i>Dahl (1971)</i>	Negative	***ELF Index: .89 (1961)	***ELF Index: .65 (1961)
High Level of Oil or Mineral Exports <i>Ross (2001)</i>	Negative	Negligible % of GDP	Negligible % of GDP
Arab State <i>Stepan and Robertson (2003)</i>	Negative	No	No
Female Subordination <i>Fish (2002)</i>	Negative	****Similar	****Similar

*Maddison Historical GDP data: www.worldeconomics.com. Accessed on 11 September 2012. These figures were largely similar in 1947.

**World Bank World Development Indicators, These are the earliest reliable and comparable figures. Given that Gini indexes for India and Pakistan remain similar in the two decades since, they were unlikely to be different in 1947. Maddison (1971) extrapolates data showing similar levels of income inequality in the 1960s. In 1960 for India and 1963 for Pakistan, pre-tax household income was calculated to be distributed as follows: Lowest three deciles in India formed 8.5% and in Pakistan formed 11.5%, middle four deciles in India formed 29.4% and in Pakistan formed 31%, and for the highest three deciles in India formed 62.1% and in Pakistan formed 57.5%. India is slightly more unequal. Comparatively speaking, these differences are marginal.

***Roeder Ethno-Linguistic Fractionalization Index. Accessed online at <http://weber.ucsd.edu/~proeder/elf.htm> 1961 ELF Data on 11 September 2012.

****Female literacy rates India changed by less than a percentage point when the regions becoming Pakistan seceded, indicating little differential in the area that became Pakistan. Government of India Census 1941 and 1951.

urban, highly educated Brahmans—a demographic that formed less than a percentage of the Indian population—they were indeed a miniscule demographic. When the colonial government responded to demands for greater indigenous representation by claiming that Congress did not represent India, this new class responded by forging a national identity that could legitimate its claim to popular representation.

Established in 1885 by these urban, educated elite, India’s independence movement, the Indian National Congress, was a pro-democratic movement because it sought

a more representative political regime. Congress first functioned as a forum to bring together these elite from across British India in order to overcome colonial objections to the devolution of political power. Congress's goals were to expand indigenous representation in colonial government, to "mould Indians into a common nation," and to create "the germ of a Native Parliament [that] if properly conducted, will constitute in a few years an unanswerable reply to the assertion that India is still unfit for any form of representative institution."⁵ Though Congressmen freely urged that the franchise for colonial advisory bodies be limited to those with education, Congress's goal of indigenous representation and the means for achieving this goal through majority voting were constitutive of a limited democratic politics.

By 1920 Congress leaders turned to mass mobilization because it proved to successfully advance electoral reforms. While Congressmen initially petitioned the colonial government for reforms, it soon became clear that the colonial regime would determinedly resist electoral reform. In this context, four historical developments spurred on Congress's embrace of mass politics. First, the contagious, widespread, and ultimately successful agitation against the 1905 partition of Bengal amply demonstrated the possibilities of mass mobilization for effecting political change.⁶ Second, the vaunted constitutional reforms of 1909 and 1919 devolved no substantive governing powers to councils, thereby discrediting the polite petitioning that had heretofore been the mainstay of Congress's activity. Third, the economic havoc wrought by the advent of World War I offered up new possibilities for harnessing mass discontents. Fourth, the demonstrated success of M. K. Gandhi in seeking colonial redress of localized disputes through nonviolent civil disobedience offered up a promising means of protest. Gandhi's interventions remained confined to localized issues until a civilian massacre of peaceful demonstrators in Jallianwala Bagh in 1919. The bloody massacre of unarmed men, women, and children, in the context of these broader structural changes, rapidly became a potent nationalist symbol of accumulating anticolonial grievances.

Congress's promotion of electoral politics threatened the (Hindu and Muslim) landed aristocracy across British India, but led to successful political organization among a geographically concentrated group of Muslim landed aristocrats. Whereas the colonial government had almost exclusively nominated titled (Hindu and Muslim) landowners to its councils before 1892, council composition changed dramatically once government conceded the elective principle through the Indian Councils Act of 1892. Only two of the six elected Indians were primarily known as landlords or *zamindars* in the Bengal council elections of 1893. By 1895 all newly elected members belonged to urban professions, a trend echoed across other regions.

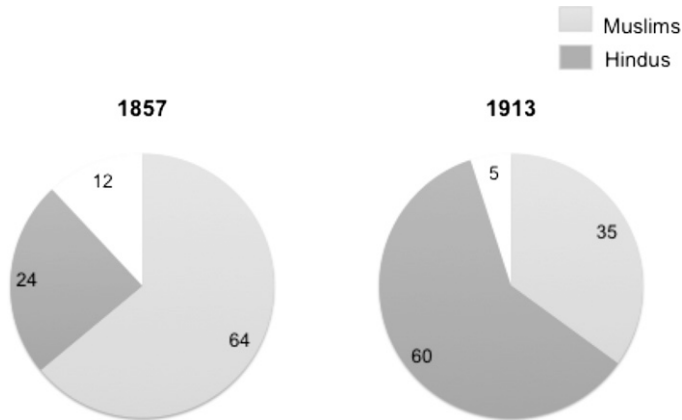
Though titled landlords throughout colonial India opposed political reform, Muslim landlords in the United Provinces (UP) organized Pakistan's eventual independence movement because they were particularly threatened by the advent of political reform and because colonial patronage legitimated their organization. Just 14 percent of UP's population, Muslims held 35 percent of civil service posts, 56 percent of high court positions, and 42 percent of the government officers in 1882. Muslims owned 20 percent

of the land in the province and were disproportionately likely to be among the large landlords. Despite the relatively greater influence of Muslims, however, religious cleavages were rarely politicized before the advent of electoral politics. Substantial numbers of Hindus learned the Persian script and served in the provincial colonial government.

Congress's proposed reforms would be particularly detrimental to the UP's influential Muslim community. In 1867 the UP provincial government explored the possibility of conducting government business in vernacular languages rather than the status quo Persian, which raised the question whether the vernacular language in question would be Hindi or Urdu. While similar spoken languages, Urdu uses a Persian-based script while Hindi uses the Devanagari script. Switching to Devanagari would disadvantage Muslims, who typically had little exposure to it in the course of their vernacular education. In the context of intense competition for lucrative colonial jobs, this question effectively cleaved the heretofore cross-communal, Urdu-speaking elite into competing groups of Hindus and Muslims.

The threat of electoral reform to colonially entrenched Muslims was similarly stark. Electoral reforms in 1892, which first introduced the elective principle, was to nearly halve Muslim representation in the UP provincial government services from 64 percent in 1857 to 35 percent in 1913, while Hindu representation more than doubled from 24 percent to 60 percent in the same period.⁷ As Figure 2 indicates, the socio-economic position of UP Muslims was immediately, deeply, and adversely impacted by electoral reform.

Figure 2 UP Provincial Government, Executive and Judicial Services



This Muslim minority thus came to believe that their interests would be best served, at least until independence became imminent, by colonially guaranteed special protections. The deleterious impact of reforms upon a well-entrenched and culturally

distinct minority, in combination with a colonial government which encouraged Muslims mobilize as a bulwark against Congress's political reforms, spurred on a movement to resist the political decline of Muslims through special protections that eventually morphed into Pakistan's independence movement. In the 1880s UP Muslims formed the Aligarh movement to oppose Muslim participation in Congress's drive for electoral reform. Its leader, Sir Syed Ahmed Khan, stated before the UP Legislative Council stated in 1887, "Would our aristocracy like that a man of low-caste or insignificant origin, though he be a B.A. or M.A. and have the requisite ability, should be in a position of authority above them and have power in making the laws that affect their lives and property? Never! Nobody would like it. (Cheers)."⁸

While Hindu landlords were similarly alarmed at the prospect of electoral reforms, they were too divided by hierarchy, language, and region to effectively mobilize. Nor were they institutionally protected by the colonial regime. Strongly overrepresented in colonial government as an accident of history, the aristocratic and culturally distinct UP Muslims could never hope to retain their current levels of influence through electoral politics. As such, they founded the Muslim League to institutionalize special political representation for Muslims, which the colonial government had long recognized as a different cultural group. When a new round of political reforms was proposed in 1906, a group of titled Muslim landowners met with the colonial Viceroy and proposed that future reforms should create separate electorates, which assigned a permanent percentage of seats to Muslims and specified that only Muslims could vote for these seats. That same year, this deputation met to formally found the Muslim League.

By its founding constitution, League membership was restricted to landed aristocrats or extremely prosperous professionals, as is apparent from its membership requirements, which specified that members earn a minimum of Rs. 500 annually at a time when British India's annual per capita income is estimated to have been around Rs. 42.⁹ The most influential position in the League was that of the League secretary, and between 1906 and 1926 this position was always held by a UP Muslim.

(In)Coherent Alliances, (Un)Programmatic Nationalisms, and (Dis)Organized Party Infrastructure

Class interests motivated the formation of political movements that alternatively promoted and resisted democratic reform. These movements subsequently transformed into dominant political parties that inherited the mantle of governing responsibility upon colonial independence. In the strategic pursuit of class interests, these political movements differentially evolved in three respects before independence—the distributive coherence of their core alliances, the ideational content of nationalisms, and their organizational depth. As a result, modern-day India and Pakistan came into being with political parties that differed considerably in terms of their ability to resolve key state-building conflicts.

Building Distributively (In)Coherent Alliances The first critical respect in which the Indian and Pakistani independence movements differentially evolved was the distributive coherence of their core alliances. The educated, urban, and predominantly Hindu middle class leading Congress created an alliance with the rural middle class. This alliance formed a coherent distributive coalition because it was composed of segments of the middle class that shared an interest in gaining control of the colonial state through a mass movement while ensuring that such a movement did not grow too revolutionary. Congressmen created this movement through civil disobedience protests that heightened the salience of shared class interests vis-à-vis the colonial regime and through a nonviolent nationalism that dampened the revolutionary potential of a mass movement.

Beginning in 1920, the urban, educated middle class represented in Congress sought to build a mass base among the relatively wealthy peasantry. As British India was overwhelmingly rural, mass support necessarily entailed rural mobilization. Within a typical Indian village, poorer peasants remained under the social and economic control of dominant peasants or upper-caste owners of land who sat at the apex of an extensive, deeply hierarchical, and village-based patronage network through their control of land and credit.¹⁰ Congress quickly learned that the most effective way to gain widespread rural support was to champion the interests of the dominant peasantry who could effectively deliver the political allegiance of the poorer peasantry. For example, the core issue at stake in Congress's first anticolonial campaign in Bardoli was the remission of higher land revenues. This mattered not to landless peasants but to those groups who owned land and were therefore responsible for remitting taxes.

Congress's involvement in limited agitations grew into a more widespread national tendency during the 1930s, as heterogeneous groups of dominant peasants saw the increasingly visible nationalist movement as an appropriate platform through which to express localized grievances. Despite a real drop in living standards, many rural cultivators faced an increased tax burden. In these historical circumstances, the strategic interests of the urban middle class and the rural dominant peasants were aligned because both would benefit from an indigenous government demanding lower tax revenues. When Congress launched its 1930 national mass mobilization campaign amidst widespread economic distress, its successful emphasis on nonviolence limited the threat of a revolutionary movement to the socioeconomically powerful dominant peasant. As the costs of participating in this movement were relatively low, Congress leaders calculated that the rural dominant peasantry and poorer social groups alike could join the nationalist movement.¹¹ Congress's success in gaining dominant peasant support was most clearly evidenced in the results of the 1937 provincial elections, based on a property-owning franchise of 11 percent, in which Congress won dramatic, majority victories in seven of eleven British provinces.

Congress's electoral success in the first meaningful elections under colonial rule awakened large landowners across British India to the imminence of independence and, with it, any guarantee of their ongoing influence in India's political life. This realization provided the League with an opportunity to capitalize on both UP Muslims'

panic and the colonial government's desire to delay political reform. To perpetuate its organizational relevance, the Muslim League struck coalitions of convenience with the organized political interests in the two major Muslim-majority provinces of Punjab and Bengal. Consequently, upon independence, the Muslim League represented an incoherent coalition whose contradictory distributive goals paralyzed political decision making in the critical regime-founding decade after independence.

The Muslim League gained electoral support in the pivotal Muslim-majority province of the Punjab through an eleventh-hour alliance with large, aristocratic landowners. A Punjabi alliance was crucial if the League was to legitimize itself as the organizational spokesman of Muslim interests in British India and therewith make demands for institutional guarantees for Muslims. Before the mid-1930s, Punjabi politics was dominated by a Hindu and Muslim landed aristocracy loosely organized into the Unionist party. Congress's electoral victories warmed landlords to the League alliance because the alliance provided national representation and would therefore help protect provincial autonomy during independence negotiations. In 1937 Unionist leaders thus encouraged their members to join the League. As the fiscal pressures of war strained the relationship between the colonial regime and Unionist landlords, and as religious polarization intensified across colonial India, League support in the Punjab grew. By 1945 the League won 33 percent of the vote in the last pre-independence provincial elections, as compared with 23 percent and 20 percent for Congress and the Unionists, respectively.¹² This electoral support was gained by short-term calculations of political interest rather than by the appeal of shared programmatic or distributive interests. The Punjabi landed aristocracy joined the League in order to maintain their hierarchical system of socioeconomic control.

In the other pivotal Muslim-majority province of Bengal, the Muslim League gained support by allying with an organized peasant movement whose political goals were incompatible with the League's core constituency of landed aristocrats. The economic recession of 1929 fueled intercommunal tensions because it dried up sources of capital that the Hindu landlords typically extended to their Muslim tenants in times of scarcity.¹³ Peasants organizing to express economic discontent culminated in the formation of the Krishak Praja Party (KPP) in 1936. The 1937 provincial elections witnessed the KPP forming a governing coalition with the Muslim League. This government played up religious divides in order to promote its electoral prospects and consequently presided over a marked rise in Muslim solidarity at the expense of Hindu-Muslim linkages.

A profound ambiguity over the Pakistan demand, first articulated by the central League in 1940, enabled the Muslim League to create and sustain an alliance with the peasant-dominated KPP. Pakistan was not clearly defined as a demand for a wholly separate Muslim state and League leaders carefully eschewed a factual discussion of Pakistan's meaning to avoid creating "dissensions" among Muslims.¹⁴ Top League leaders often referred to Pakistan using the word "states" rather than "state," suggesting that Bengal could either become independent or gain substantial autonomy within the framework of a united India. In his opinion, the Governor of Bengal felt

that Pakistan, to most Muslims, meant that Muslims, rather than Hindus would own the stores.¹⁵ This vague content notwithstanding, the Bengal elections of 1945–1946 were fought and won on the demand for Pakistan, with the League winning 115 of 123 allotted Muslim seats. The victory enabled the League to preside over the creation of a Pakistani state in which the League's core supporters were landed aristocrats in the Punjab and a cultivating tenantry in Bengal, a coalition of diametrically opposed distributive interests.

Propagating (Un)Programmatic Nationalisms The second critical respect in which the Indian and Pakistani independence movements differentially evolved was their programmatic nationalisms. While both independence movements defined their nations in contradistinction to outsiders, only the Indian independence movement defined a nationalism specifying a set of programmatic principles. Upon independence, the presence of Congress's programmatic commitments facilitated India's regime stability while the absence of such content paralyzed Pakistani politics to such a degree that autocratic intervention eventually ensued. Moreover, the institutionalized content of Congress's political program greatly facilitated the establishment of India's democracy because such content included defining democratic institutions.

Early Congressmen understood that creating a national community first necessitated forging a public sphere where would-be citizens could conceptualize themselves as equals. As caste-based hierarchies pervaded every aspect of social and economic life in colonial India, a public sphere in which individuals were imagined to be equal citizens simply did not exist. Congress's acceptance of hierarchical caste identities hampered its ability to promote political reform because the colonial regime justified its unwillingness to cede representative institutions by asserting that colonial India remained a despotic society exploited by upper castes represented in Congress.

Congress's consequent attempts to forge an egalitarian national identity took a number of forms, but are most clearly exemplified by its efforts to halt the public recognition of "untouchability." Untouchables comprised approximately 10 percent of the population and formed the lowest Hindu caste. Their caste status denied them equal use of roads, schools, hospitals, wells, and parks. Their public subordination posed a substantial obstacle to the creation of an egalitarian nationalism. Around 1920, at Gandhi's urging, Congressmen began to preach and practice equality in intercaste interactions in public places.¹⁶ Such seemingly minor changes in acts of everyday living were impactful because they signaled the creation of a public sphere in which an egalitarian Indian nation was not just imagined but lived. Top Congress leaders, almost without exception, engaged themselves publicly with the rejection of untouchability and actively supported Congress's mobilization against caste discrimination. In 1920 Congress passed its first resolution clearly advocating the removal of untouchability, and established an affiliated organization, Harijan Seva Sangh, specifically to promote its abolition.

Congress's consistent campaigns against caste distinctions over the next three decades, even when recognizing that caste hierarchies could have advanced short-term

political reform, evidence a far-sighted commitment to their class-based goals. When proposed political reforms awarded separate electorates to untouchables in 1932, Congressmen objected on the grounds that these would institutionalize caste distinctions, thereby preventing the growth of a single national consciousness. This response, based on the understanding that accepting caste-based reform would undermine the long-term success of Congress's movement, drove the institutionalization of political equality within the party. This was done by consistently mobilizing against untouchability and by linking these efforts with Indian nationalism. Although Congressmen initially embraced egalitarian nationalism in order to gain a mass base, the espoused egalitarian content of nationalism eventually assumed meaning independent of its capacity to advance the goal of political reform because it became widely institutionalized within the party. By the time of independence, an egalitarian nationalism was the ideational mainstay of Congress's movement and therefore not easily contradicted in the building of the new regime.

By contrast, the Muslim League articulated a Pakistani nationalism that remained instrumental until independence. Before 1937 the League consistently described Muslims as a minority whose rights needed protecting within a united India. The League's demand for a sovereign Muslim state came about as a direct result of the provincial elections in which the party failed to garner significant electoral support. After 1937 the League began to assert that Muslims constituted a separate nation. By 1940 Jinnah elaborated the demand for a separate and sovereign state for Muslims. The conception of Hindus and Muslims as distinct national communities enabled the League to claim organizational parity with Congress within independence negotiations.

That Pakistani nationalism remained instrumental up until independence is evidenced by the League's willingness to renounce the primary principle of Pakistani nationalism once independence had been achieved. Mere days before Pakistan's independence in August 1947, Jinnah stated before Pakistan's Constituent Assembly that,

"You may belong to any religion or caste or creed—that has nothing to do with the business of the State...You will find that in course of time Hindus would cease to be Hindus and Muslims would cease to be Muslims, not in the religious sense, because that is the personal faith of each individual, but in the political sense as citizens of the State."¹⁷

Heretofore, the central claim of Pakistani nationalism had been that a sovereign state needed to be created because Muslims formed a distinct nation. That this claim was being contradicted by the League's dominant leader on the eve of national independence attests to the fact that Pakistani nationalism remained primarily a means to the end.

Moreover, throughout the decade before its independence, Pakistan's nationalist movement was defined by its opposition to Congress's rule rather than by specific programs or principles. A review of the League's annual meetings between 1940 and 1947 reveals that while about a third of these meetings was devoted to maligning Congress or the colonial regime, less than a tenth defined the League's vision for an independent

state in any substantive manner.¹⁸ In the crucial years before the League would be responsible for governing Pakistan, there was, for example, no discussion of the basic rights which a Pakistani constitution would protect, of the basic power-sharing agreement between its constituent units, and no clarification on the role religion would play in the state. This contrasted markedly with a Congress leadership that was carefully contemplating the specific economic and social policies that an independent India would adopt.

Finally, to the extent that Pakistani nationalism did have programmatic content, it rejected the defining process of democracy, namely, competitive elections based one vote per individual. The League charge of a “tyranny of the Hindu majority” in an independent India would have been meaningful if the League had sought constitutional guarantees for particular religious or cultural rights. But this was not so. In 1931 Congress had already agreed that it would adopt no constitutional decision with which a majority of either the Hindu or Muslim community disagreed. Instead, the League was demanding that Muslims, as approximately a quarter of the population, be guaranteed one-third of the seats in a central legislature and effective veto power over independence negotiations. League nationalism was thus inconsistent with the defining process of democracy, majority rule based on one vote per individual in the context of protected civil rights.

Creating (Dis)organized Political Parties The final respect in which the Indian and Pakistani independence movements evolved differently before independence was their organizational robustness. Congress leaders honed a complex party organization before independence. They provided for the cohesion of the Indian independence movement by creating an accountable but empowered leadership and by allowing for some bottom-up expression of grievances. Through its 1920 constitution, Congress’s organizational structure was reformulated to consist of a president, three general secretaries, and an All-India Congress Committee (AICC) elected by Provincial Congress Committees, which was in turn elected by District, Taluka, and Town Congress Committees.¹⁹ Each party level was elected by the organization below it, thereby reaching downward into colonial India’s 700,000 villages. Congress’s most important bodies were the AICC, a quasi-parliament, and the Congress Working Committee (CWC, created in 1921, and comprised of just fifteen members), a quasi-cabinet. All of Congress’s binding decisions were taken by a majority vote of either the AICC or CWC.

This new organization allowed the party to attract more grassroots support. Provincial Congress Committees were now to be organized into twenty-one linguistically homogenous provinces that were encouraged to conduct party business in local languages. The All-India Congress was conducted in Hindi as much as possible, rendering participation more possible for the less educated. Paid membership was also introduced, though at a sufficiently low level (4 annas, or ¼ of a rupee) that it enabled all but the very poorest to participate in the party. Nonpaying members were also allowed to join Congress as long as they pledged to uphold Congress’s creed.

Congress drastically improved its financial position after 1920. Annual membership dues provided a regular source of income. The Tilak Memorial Swaraj Fund, launched by Gandhi to solicit funds from the business community, collected 10 million rupees in 1921. From its rural membership drives, Congress raised over 13 million rupees.²⁰ The approximately 25 million rupees raised between 1921 and 1923 amounted to approximately \$250,000, a good deal of money at that time. Because Congressmen often also received in-kind contributions, such as free train travel from sympathetic ticket collectors, these funds enabled Congress to extensively popularize the anticolonial movement.

In part due to such changes, Congress's membership surged during the late 1920s and early 1930s. While the reliability of these numbers is somewhat suspect, Congress's membership stood at two million in 1921, four and a half million in 1938, and five and a half million in 1945, at a time when less than a tenth of colonial India's three hundred million individuals were literate.²¹ Particularly after Congress began governing provincial governments in 1937, this growth in primarily rural membership likely represented an opportunistic conversion to the organization likely to govern an independent India. Nonetheless, since Congress possessed large membership rolls already by 1921, when joining Congress was a politically risky thing to do, these numbers also genuinely reflect Congress's growing popularity.

Congress's well-developed party infrastructure allowed it to effectively discipline party members. In Punjab, for example, where Congress represented primarily urban moneylenders, all-India Congress leaders gave orders for provincial Congress organizations to support an anti-money-lending bill, orders that were largely obeyed. Congress leaders were also able to prevent provincial congressmen adversely affected by the 1932 Communal Award from openly condemning it, vehement internal dissension notwithstanding.²² That the national congressional leadership was able to keep its provincial members from opposing policies which contradicted their own short-term material and political interests evidences the causal significance of the party in and of itself.

By contrast, the Muslim League possessed little party infrastructure, particularly in those geographical areas that came to constitute Pakistan. Obedience to the party's charismatic leader was the defining characteristic of those who rose to positions of power in the League. Before 1937 the League often failed to gain a quorum for its annual meetings. In 1938 the League created a Working Committee that allowed Jinnah to personally nominate its members for every year before independence.²³ Resolutions passed by the Working Committee after 1938 further centralized power in the President. That the League was under Jinnah's virtual monopoly was epitomized in 1939, when a member of the Working Committee criticized Jinnah for announcing the League's "Day of Deliverance" without consulting the League's Working Committee. In response, the League resolved that no standing member of the Working Committee could publicly criticize the President.²⁴

Its leaders' aggrandizement of power aggravated the League's lack of organizational depth. Not a single annual League session in the decade before independence was held in Bengal, despite the fact that it was the most populous Muslim province

in colonial India and would singlehandedly form a popular majority in what became Pakistan. After 1943 the Bengal League did undertake to create a mass base, lowering membership fees, undertaking rural membership drives, and even organizing a provincial Working Committee. But though the Bengal League developed grassroots support, it remained disconnected from the national League leadership because the central party organization was under Jinnah's exclusive grip. Because the Bengal League had to contend with the very different economic and political interests of its parent organization, it remained politically sidelined until well after independence.

In the other pivotal province of Punjab, the League's membership rolls also remained slight. By 1941 the League had enrolled just 15,000 members in its six active districts of Punjab, whereas in ten districts no League organization existed at all.²⁵ The Unionists, with whom the League had aligned, relied nearly exclusively on their traditional social authority to win votes in the 1937 elections.²⁶ Indeed, the League-Unionist alliance meant that the existing rural hierarchy, with large landowners wielding extraordinary socioeconomic power over small landowners and the landless, remained fully in control of provincial politics until the eve of Pakistani independence. The League's lack of a developed party organization directly impacted its ability to effectively address state-building challenges after independence.

Dominant Parties Broker Stable Democracy and Unstable Autocracy

The creation of respected rules for transferring power within a constitution is a hallmark of a stable regime. Where those rules specify the selection of a chief executive by free and fair elections, it is also the hallmark of a democratic regime. The impact of each country's dominant party upon its democratic character and stability during its inaugural independence decade can be explored by investigating how these parties shaped key decisions and challenges (for example, constitution writing and suffrage rights) that defined each country's ultimate regime trajectory.

In 1947 British India formally transferred the sovereignty of colonial India to two successor states. While Pakistan received a disproportionately larger share of refugees as well as a smaller share of state resources, these differences were not massively inequitable. The Indian Independence Act had stipulated that the Constituent Assemblies of India and Pakistan, bodies elected by the pre-independence provincial assemblies, formulate each country's constitution. Examining whether and how each country ratified its constitution shows the democratic divergence between India and Pakistan.²⁷

The Congress party was almost solely responsible for the speedy adoption of India's constitution. Congress members formed over three-quarters of the Assembly, including fourteen members of the CWC. Before even the precise structural contours of the sovereign successor state were known, a Congress Assembly Party was debating and drafting constitutional provisions. The leaders of the Congress party took particular care to broaden the representation of the Constituent Assembly at a time when the party's strategic position did not require it to do so, reflecting a democratic inclination

forged over the pre-independence decades by an urban, educated middle class needing to maintain unified mass support throughout a prolonged anticolonial struggle.

Congress's institutionalized commitment to universal adult suffrage most clearly explained its decision to formalize universal adult franchise within the Indian constitution. When the 1928 Nehru Report first suggested the adoption of universal adult suffrage, its author admitted that universal suffrage was a facile way of dealing with the different claims of religious communities to political representation.²⁸ Universal suffrage was proposed in 1930 and mainstreamed as Congress policy after the 1932 Poona Pact in order to keep subordinate social groups within the party fold. Nevertheless, after independence, Congress leaders could readily have reneged on the commitment to universal suffrage, as there was no longer an immediate need to mobilize mass support. But since Congress had gained broad support through its commitment to the adult franchise, instituting property or literacy qualifications would have certainly alienated some of its support base. Consequently, Congress leaders rejected any qualifications and wrote universal suffrage into the constitution at a time when their narrow class interests did not compel them to do so, reflecting the workings of an institutional rather than a purely class logic. The content of Congress's institutionalized commitments before independence thus explains its decision to create this constitutive democratic institution.

India's constitution was also speedily adopted because the constitution-making process was governed by a developed party organization. Constituent Assembly leaders typically made decisions by seeking consensus, subsequently aiming to bring the party rank and file into line through persuasion. Unlike Pakistan's Muslim League, however, Congress included a handful of men with considerable stature who could and did challenge its leader on numerous issues. When party chiefs disagreed, such as they did over the extent and manner in which large landlords were to be compensated for *zamindari* (large titled landlord) abolition, these leaders all eventually consented to compromise. Leadership was crucial in taking deciding key constitutional questions, but this leadership was created within the party before independence, both because such individuals had risen up through party ranks and because these leaders had demonstrated a nationalist commitment. Even when Congress leaders agreed, they typically reached decisions on controversial constitutional issues within the Assembly through supermajority votes. Disagreement was notably resolved not by undermining or eliminating party opposition, but through extensive debate, appeals to patriotism, and, ultimately, party discipline.

Finally, it bears repeating that the organizational and ideational development of India's dominant political party was predicated upon, and therefore fundamentally enabled by, a coherent distributive coalition. That the Congress party still reflected the interests of a distinct alliance of classes is most clearly evidenced in the constitutional debate over the abolition of large landowning estates. The most notable feature of the Constituent Assembly debates on *zamindari* (large titled landlord) abolition is that there was unanimous support among Congress leaders for the general proposition that they be abolished. The uncontroversial nature of land reform within

the party was powerful evidence that Congress did not represent the interests of large landowners who sat at the apex of India's colonial power structure. In sum, Congress's procedural discipline, its commitment to a shared programmatic platform, and, no less crucially, its underlying class basis of support, all facilitated speedy and democratic compromises on the same issues around which Pakistan's constitution-making process broke down.

The inability of Pakistan's dominant political party to broker political compromises was directly responsible for three successive failures to produce a Pakistani constitution. The Muslim League was as dominant in Pakistan's Constituent Assembly as Congress was in India's, possessing fifty-nine of seventy-four Assembly delegates.²⁹ However, even before constitution-making in Pakistan began in earnest, the Muslim League's lack of organizational or ideational infrastructure was evident in the workings of provincial politics. For example, when the Governor of Punjab complained to Jinnah in 1948 that the League's Chief Minister in Punjab was deeply corrupt, Jinnah attempted to engineer the Minister's resignation but was unable to do so because the proposed successor was also a large landlord who did not wish to oppose his predecessor. Even the direct lobbying of the League's single charismatic leader at the height of his powers failed to compel one Punjabi landlord to act against another, demonstrating how class interests trumped party discipline. At the time, provincial politicians were seen to have, "to everyone's knowledge, defeated the centre, even the Quaid [Jinnah]. . . and the feeling is growing that the centre is powerless. . ."³⁰ Immediately upon independence, the clearest differentiating factor between India's and Pakistan's constitutional development was the inability of its dominant political party to discipline provincial politicians, a direct legacy of the way the party gained support before independence.

Upon Jinnah's death in 1948, executive leadership of the country passed to Prime Minister Khan, who produced an "Objectives Resolution" that stated the goals of the Pakistani constitution in sufficiently ambiguous terms as to provoke little opposition. But by mid-1950, after India ratified its constitution, any clear specification of the constitutional power allocation had yet to emerge in Pakistan.

The division of constitutional powers between the federal center and constituent states provoked bitter debate that Pakistan's dominant political party was unable to resolve. When League leaders produced a first constitutional draft stipulating strong centralization of powers, both Bengali and Punjabi provincial politicians objected to critical aspects of this draft—Bengalis opposing the proposed adoption of Urdu as the sole national language and Punjabis objecting to the strong centralization of power. Based on these objections, the Prime Minister withdrew the proposed constitution.

In the absence of a well-organized political force to govern by brokering political compromises, political deadlock and consequent regime instability slowly but steadily intensified. The second attempt at constitution-making similarly culminated in deadlock over power-sharing between the provinces and between the provinces and federal center. It was summarily rejected by a Punjabi landed aristocracy that perceived little need to assent to a curtailment of its power. Punjabis feared that the Bengalis, already

a majority, would be able to legislatively dominate the Punjabis by creating alliances with smaller units in West Pakistan. Bengali domination was unacceptable to Punjabi landlords because Bengal's social structure led its representatives to propose redistributive political policies such as land reform. Punjabi opposition to the constitutional draft was so strong that the Prime Minister withdrew the proposed constitution in January 1953. On the pretext of a worsening economic situation, the Governor-General autocratically dismissed the Prime Minister a few weeks later.

The Assembly's final attempt to create a constitution followed the same pattern of deadlock over power-sharing specifications and reflected the continuing inability of the League to utilize party discipline or programmatic commitments to broker state-building compromises. The Constituent Assembly proposed a bicameral legislature with power equally apportioned between houses. Though this arrangement was ultimately approved, an alliance of civilian bureaucrats and Punjabi landlords also coalesced to derail this constitutional draft. Just before the constitution was set to be ratified, the governing Punjabi Chief Minister Firoz Khan Noon and Governor-General Ghulam Mohammad announced their opposition to the latest constitutional draft and engineered the Assembly's dismissal in 1954.³¹ As Bengali provincial elections in the same year had also voted the League out of power, Pakistan's dominant political party ceased to possess any meaningful influence on Pakistani politics.

The breakdown of the Muslim League as a (weak but nonetheless present) organizing force led to a rapid proliferation of administrations, with many of the same several dozen leaders cycling through key cabinet positions until the military coup of 1958. Four prime ministers came to power in as many years, some remaining for mere months, signifying an inability to pursue a shared governing agenda. The final civilian administration in power was a coalition of six different parties, both a reflection and a cause of party inability to govern effectively. In 1958 the prospect of national elections which may have legitimated provincial politicians led President Iskander Mirza, a civilian bureaucrat, together with the Army Chief of Staff, Ayub Khan, to abrogate the constitution, abolish political parties, and declare martial law. Within the same month, the military formally took over, announcing a military authoritarian regime that was to last for eleven years.

In sum, post-independence constitution-making in Pakistan was stalled by the inability of its dominant political party to draw on shared distributive goals, on party discipline, or on an institutionalized ideational commitment to facilitate power-sharing compromises. Party weakness was a direct result of the way the party had mobilized support before independence, when it built support for Pakistan by reinforcing the socioeconomic power of the rural landed aristocracy in one area of the country and by allying with a peasant movement in the other area. The conflicting distributive interests of its core alliance meant that, after independence, Pakistan's dominant political party could mobilize its supporters around neither a specific policy platform nor defined procedures for making governing decisions. As a direct result of party weakness, Pakistan's civilian bureaucracy and military slowly aggrandized power, eventually ending Pakistan's fledgling democratic experiment.

Conclusion

This comparative historical analysis of India's and Pakistan's post-independence regime outcomes highlights the centrality of political parties in explaining post-colonial regime stability and democratization while also emphasizing that the initial creation of such parties hinges on the historically specific socioeconomic interests of powerful social groups. In 1947 India and Pakistan did not have radically different social structures. Both had titled hereditary landowners, a tiny urban, educated class, many relatively well-to-do peasants, and millions of poorer peasants. Nor were their levels of income or inequality significantly different. Thus, a theoretical focus on ahistorical economic characteristics is inadequate to explain India and Pakistan's divergent regime trajectories. Instead, the strategic interaction of class interests and the imperatives of colonial rule spurred on different mobilization strategies among the two countries' founding parties. These strategies saw India's landed aristocracy excluded while Pakistan's landed aristocracy was empowered, which contributed to the creation of a coherent class coalition in India and an incoherent class coalition in Pakistan. These strategies also included varying levels of institutionalized, programmatic commitments and party organization. These strategies and their institutional legacies account for the divergent regime trajectories of India and Pakistan.

Specifically, when powerful social groups felt their socioeconomic mobility was impeded by the colonial regime, they were more likely to mobilize mass support and organize political institutions to challenge a powerful colonial state. When, instead, powerful social groups felt that colonial patronage protected their interests, there was much less incentive to create programmatic, well-organized political parties. In the context of a relatively developed state apparatus and a underdeveloped market economy characteristic of postcolonial polities, how social groups pursued upward mobility and how they chose to mobilize popular bases of support were not determined by economic interests alone. Colonial patterns of patronage critically influenced the post-independence regime trajectories through their impact upon group incentives to create and institutionalize political parties.

Thus, this research emphasizes that the relationship between distributive conflict on the one hand and regime stability on the other hand can be mediated through the construction of robust organizations, typically in the form of political parties, which can alter how distributive conflicts matter for regime outcomes. While an analytical emphasis on the relative distribution of power among class groups is historically well grounded in the study of comparative democratization, such literature has tended to privilege the changing distribution of power between social classes and the alignments of social classes prior to regime-founding moments and devoted little analytic space to how political parties emerge from and in turn condition class interests. Once created, parties can do much more than serve as a locus for aggregating given preferences. Party institutions can themselves alter the strategic interests of powerful social groups.

Moreover, this analysis contributes to the scholarly literature concerned with explaining regime stability through the functioning of political parties.³² The argument

developed in the cases of India and Pakistan echoes the importance of political parties in facilitating regime stability. But it also emphasizes that viewing political parties as the primary explanation for regime stability neglects to move further back along the causal chain of explanation and problematize the circumstances under which political parties first gained the support of key elites. The comparison of regime origins in India and Pakistan demonstrates that, at their inception, political parties were no more than an array of social groups coming together to pursue short-term material gains, and that their incentives to coordinate power sharing hinged critically on historically specific perceptions of shared interests. In one case, this alliance forged respected rules for sharing power and espoused ideologies facilitating cooperation. When these rules became regularized and national ideologies came to matter as an end in itself, then political parties became causally independent brokers of regime stability. But whether or not parties emerged as robust institutions first hinged on whether the allied social groups were able to forge basic power-sharing compromises. This suggests that an institutional dynamic is only able to emerge and provide for regime stability when its dominant political party represents a stable compromise on key issues of distribution.

Finally, political parties in postcolonial India and Pakistan came into being to serve the needs of powerful and organized social groups who allied in the shared pursuit of upward mobility. When these social classes struck distributive compromises, espoused programmatic platforms, and evolved a complex party organization—in short, when they created robust political parties before independence—the parties were able to broker post-independence regime stability. As elsewhere, the granting of colonial independence did not fundamentally alter social or political structures in India and Pakistan, but it did often alter power-sharing incentives. The evidence presented here shows that parties were significantly more likely to broker regime stability after independence if stable bases of support were institutionalized before the transition to independence. In making this argument, this article builds upon an emerging strand of research stressing the critical importance of national transitions for understanding postcolonial regime trajectories.³³ Where political parties had organized and institutionalized widespread political support before these transitions, regime stability was more likely to emerge. Where, however, the dominant political party neither struck distributive compromises nor institutionalized power-sharing mechanisms before independence, post-independence regime instability was likely to ensue.

NOTES

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1. Carles Boix, *Democracy and Redistribution* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003) focuses on standard measures of income inequality to explain democratization across cases. Daron Acemoglu and James Robinson, *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University

Press, 2006), 31–42, list six major determinants of democratization, including civil society development; economic crises; sources of income and wealth; political institutions, such as constitutions; intergroup equality; and globalization.

2. For contingent class cleavages, see Barrington Moore, *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1966); and Dietrich Rueschemeyer, Evelyn Stephens, and John Stephens, *Capitalism, Development, and Democracy* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1992). For elite divides, see Guillermo O'Donnell and Philippe Schmitter, *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986); and Deborah Yashar, *Demanding Democracy* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1997).

3. Beatriz Magaloni, *Voting For Autocracy* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2006); and Jason Brownlee, *Authoritarianism in an Age of Democratization* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2007).

4. Lord Dufferin, Letter 118, Volume 5, Letters from Dufferin to Cross, No. 25, *Cross Papers*, India Office Library, hereafter IOL.

5. Akbar Zaidi, ed., *Proceedings of the Indian National Congress, Volume I: The Founding Fathers* (Delhi: Indian Institute of Applied Political Research, 1990), 39.

6. The colonial government announced plans to partition the province of Bengal into two provinces. This was proposed in order to weaken the anti-colonial agitation which was centered in the province.

7. Francis Robinson, *Separatism among Indian Muslims* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1993), 46.

8. Sir Syed Ahmed Khan, Speech at Lucknow, dated September 28, 1887, in Nehru Memorial Museum and Library, hereafter NMML, New Delhi.

9. Muslim League Proceedings of 1907, Microfiche, National Archives of Pakistan, hereafter NAP.

10. David Anthony Low, ed., *Congress and the Raj* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006).

11. *Ibid.*

12. *Return Showing the Results of Elections to the Central Legislative Assembly and the Provincial Legislatures in 1945–1946*, National Archives of India, hereafter NAI.

13. Burdwan Fortnightly Report to Viceroy on July 10, 1941, Confidential File 13/41, *Wavell Papers*, IOL.

14. AIML session at Delhi, April 24 to 26, 1943, in Nicholas Mansergh, ed., *The Transfer of Power*, Vol. III hereafter TP (London: H.M.S.O., 1970), 921–22.

15. Lord Casey, *Personal Experience* (London: Constable, 1962).

16. Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi (Desai, ed.), *An Autobiography* (Delhi: Beacon Press, [1949]1993), 383.

17. M. A. Jinnah, Address to the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan, August 11, 1947, accessed at http://www.pakistan.org/pakistan/legislation/constituent_address_11aug1947.html.

18. Annual Meetings, Muslim League Papers, NAP.

19. *Indian National Congress, 1920–1923* (Allahabad, All-India Congress Committee, 1924): 38–51, NMML.

20. *Ibid.*, 331–38.

21. All-India Congress Committee Papers, Files G-24 (1921), 4–50 (1946), NMML.

22. *Ibid.*

23. S. S. Pirzada, *Foundations of Pakistan: All-India Muslim League Documents, 1906–1947* (Karachi, National Publishing House, 1969).

24. Harun Rashid, *The Foreshadowing of Bangladesh: Bengal Muslim League and Muslim Politics, 1936–1947*. (Dhaka: Asiatic Society of Bangladesh, 1987), 113.

25. Ian Talbot, *Provincial Politics and the Pakistan Movement* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1988), 90.

26. Emerson to Linlithgow, October 19, 1936, IOR R/3/1/1, p. 10, IOL.

27. For a discussion of how party strength explains Indian and Pakistani regime outcomes in other dimensions, see Maya Tudor, *The Promise of Power* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2013), chap. 5.

28. Nehru Report of 1928, pp. 92–93, NMML.

29. Golam Choudhury, *Constitutional Development in Pakistan* (Dacca, 1954), 20.

30. Mudie-Liaquat Ali Khan Correspondence, January 10, 1949, MSS Eur. F164/51. IOL.

31. Allen McGrath, *The Destruction of Pakistan's Democracy* (Karachi: Oxford University Press, 1996), 122.

32. See endnote 3.

33. Ben Smith, "Life of the Party: The Origins of Regime Breakdown Under Single Party Rule," *World Politics*, 57 (April 2005), 421–51; and Rachel Riedl, "Institutions in New Democracies: Variations in African Political Party Systems," Princeton University, 2008.